and Bhabha promised that it would take him only eighteen months. Immediately after China's test in 1964, Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri reportedly authorized Bhabha to estimate what would be required for a peaceful nuclear explosion. An overt military option risked jeopardizing India's civil nuclear programme, which still benefited from US and Canadian assistance, and so a PNE was the only real option. But this proved more difficult than promised. Bhabha sought assistance—specifically blueprints—from the United States, which independently considered the possibility of conducting nuclear tests on behalf of non-Communist countries in Asia, including India. [58] After Bhabha died in a plane crash in 1966, his successor Vikram Sarabhai expressed much greater reservations about the PNE programme and slowed down its authorized development.

But by the mid-1960s, another important development had occurred: the advent of a nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT). In 1965, in multilateral negotiations, India laid out its parameters for agreeing to such a treaty. They included the non-transfer of nuclear weapon technology, a no-first-use commitment against non-nuclear states, a UN security guarantee, a commitment to disarmament, and only in these circumstances a commitment by non-nuclear powers to not acquire weapons. From India's standpoint, these criteria would have blunted China's nuclear advantage. On the other end of the spectrum, the US and Soviet Union envisioned a much narrower treaty that prohibited the transfer of weapons and technology to non-weapon states, the acquisition of nuclear weapons by non-weapon states, and verification that fuel, equipment, and technology would not be diverted for military use. Their suggestion would essentially have closed off the possibility of India acquiring nuclear weapons, or even conducting a peaceful nuclear explosion. India, along with several other countries, also felt that the US proposal downplayed disarmament obligations and was morally questionable, in that it created nuclear haves and have-nots. In the context of its security problems with China and the existing Indian programme, this was enormously problematic. [59]

Despite New Delhi's objections, a draft NPT was presented by the United States and the Soviet Union in August 1967 that largely adhered to their